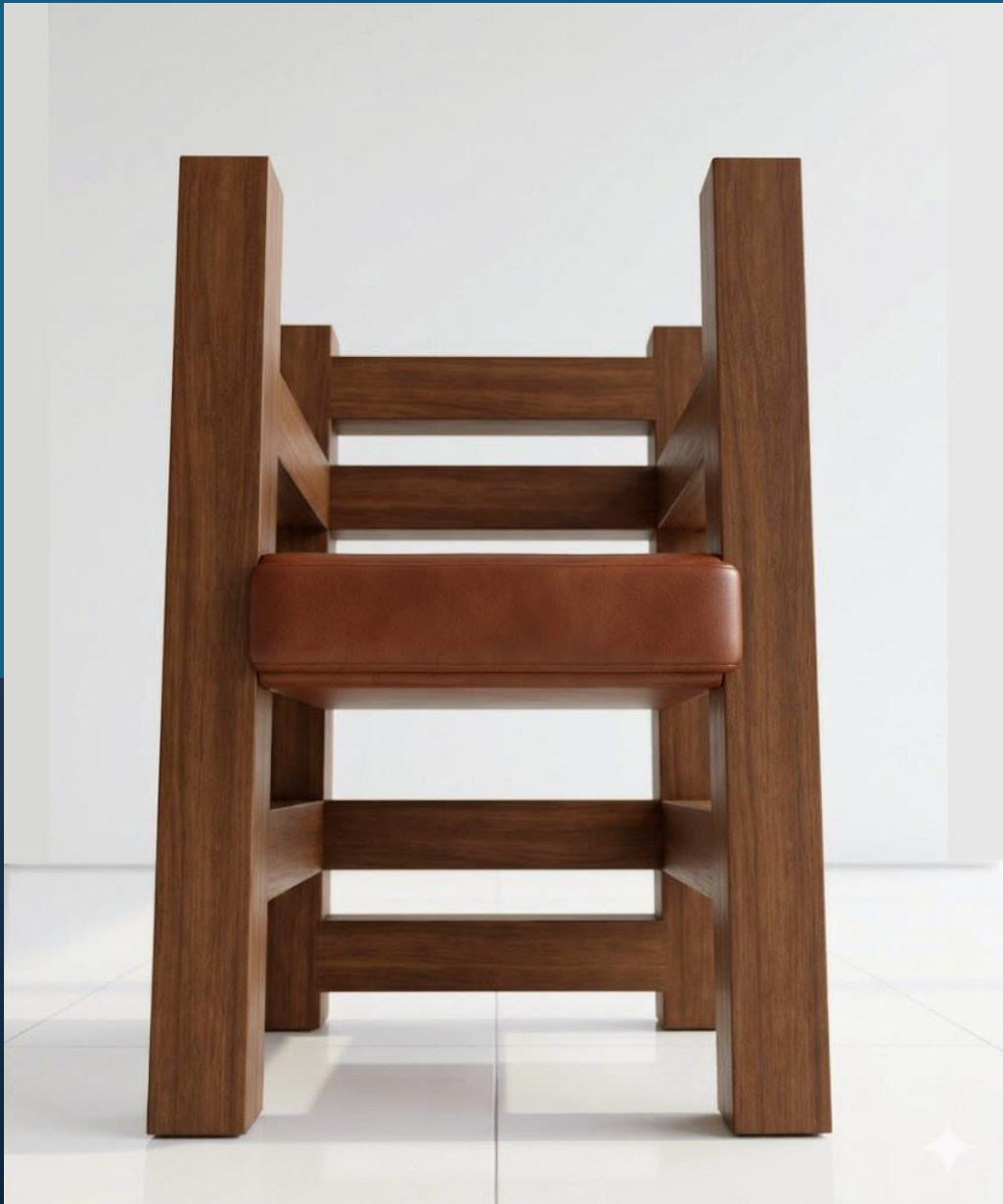




The Throne: A Visual Symbol of Perceptual Disruption

IBRAHEM SHALABI

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Author: Ibrahim Shalaby (Founder of the Post-Perception Movement)

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Introduction: The Most Ordinary Object Becomes the Most Extraordinary Question

Every art movement needs a symbol. Something simple. Something memorable. Something that captures, in a single image, the central question of the movement.

Surrealism had the melting clock. Pop Art had the soup can. Dada had the urinal. Postmodernism had the fragmented image.

Post-Perception has a chair.

Not a throne made of gold, encrusted with jewels, towering over the viewer. Not a throne of power, of authority, of majesty. A simple chair. Oak wood. Precise geometric symmetry. Designed to be functional, comfortable, and unremarkable.

But this chair has a secret. It is designed to work in two opposite orientations. You can sit on it in the normal position – legs on the floor, back behind you. Or you can flip it upside down – legs in the air, back beneath you – and sit on it again. Either way, it remains a fully functional chair.

The chair asks a simple question: "What is a chair?"

And then it asks a deeper question: "Is what we see enough to know what something is?"

And then it asks the deepest question of all: "If the most familiar object in your daily life can be turned upside down and still function perfectly, what else in your perception is ready to be inverted?"

This is The Throne. It is the visual symbol of Post-Perception. And this article explains why a chair – of all things – became the emblem for a movement dedicated to testing the limits of human perception in the digital age.

art One: Why a Chair?

When I first told people that the symbol of Post-Perception would be a chair, many were confused. A chair? Not something more dramatic? Not a broken screen, a glitched image, a melting face? Not something that obviously symbolizes technology, deception, or confusion?

No. A chair.

Here is why.

A chair is one of the most familiar objects in human experience. You have seen thousands of chairs in your life. You have sat on chairs in your home, in your school, in your workplace, in restaurants, in parks, in waiting rooms. You do not think about chairs. You just use them. A chair is invisible in its familiarity.

This is exactly why a chair is the perfect symbol for Post-Perception.

The movement is not about exotic, strange, or rare perceptual phenomena. It is not about hallucinations, psychedelic experiences, or mystical visions. It is about the perception of ordinary things – the things you see every day, touch every day, use every day, and never question.

If I can make you question a chair – something so familiar that you have never once doubted what it is – then I can make you question anything. If a chair can be turned upside down and still function as a chair, then your assumptions about "up" and "down," about "function" and "form," about "obvious" and "certain" are all open to examination.

The chair is ordinary. The question it raises is extraordinary.

Part Two: The Design of The Throne

Let me describe The Throne in detail.

The Material

The chair is made of solid oak wood. Oak is strong, durable, and heavy. It is the wood of furniture that lasts for generations. There is nothing fragile or temporary about this chair. It is built to endure.

I chose oak for a specific reason. The questions Post-Perception asks are not lightweight questions for casual entertainment. They are serious questions about the nature of reality, perception, and truth. The chair must feel serious. It must have weight, both literally and metaphorically.

The Symmetry

The chair is designed with precise geometric symmetry. Every part of the chair has a corresponding part on the opposite side. The left leg mirrors the right leg. The front edge mirrors the back edge. The seat is perfectly level. The back is perfectly straight.

This symmetry is not accidental. It is the key to the chair's secret function. Because the chair is perfectly symmetrical, you cannot tell which end is "up" just by looking at it. The legs could be on the floor. Or they could be in the air. The back could be behind you. Or it could be beneath you. The chair gives you no visual clue about its orientation.

The Function

Despite the symmetry, despite the confusion about which end is up, the chair remains fully functional in both orientations. Sit on it the normal way. It holds your weight. Your back rests against the back. Your feet touch the floor. Sit on it upside down. The legs become a kind of backrest. The original back becomes a kind of seat. Your feet still reach the floor (if the chair is designed to the right height). You are still comfortable. You are still supported.

The chair does not care which way is up. It works either way.

The Question

The chair does not come with instructions. It does not have a sign telling you which orientation is correct. It does not have a label saying "this end up" or "this side forward." You have to decide for yourself.

Some people sit on it the normal way without thinking. They have seen chairs their entire lives. They know how a chair works. They do not need to examine it. They just sit.

Other people hesitate. They notice the symmetry. They wonder if there is a trick. They examine the chair from different angles. They touch the wood. They test the stability. They think before they sit.

A few people try the upside-down orientation. They flip the chair over. They sit with their legs in the air, their back against the original back, their feet dangling or resting on the legs. They laugh. They feel strange. They experience the familiar object in an unfamiliar way.

All of these reactions are correct. There is no wrong way to sit on The Throne. There is only awareness or unawareness. The chair rewards those who pay attention. It does not punish those who do not. But it leaves a mark on both. Once you have seen a chair that works upside down, you never look at chairs the same way again.

Part Three: What The Throne Teaches About Perception

The Throne is not just a piece of furniture. It is a perceptual teaching tool. It trains you in five important lessons.

Lesson One: Familiarity is Not Understanding

You have sat on chairs your entire life. You know what a chair is. You know how to use a chair. But do you really understand what a chair is? Could you define it? Could you list its essential features? Could you explain why a chair with perfect symmetry still functions when inverted?

Most people cannot. They have used chairs for decades without ever thinking about what a chair actually is. Their familiarity is not understanding. It is just habit.

The same is true of so many things in your perception. You see images online every day. You assume they are real. But do you actually know? Have you checked? Have you questioned? Or are you just relying on habit?

Lesson Two: Orientation is Convention, Not Fact

The Throne teaches that "up" and "down" are not absolute facts. They are conventions. They depend on context, on expectation, on agreement.

When you sit on The Throne upside down, your body is comfortable. Your weight is supported. Your back is rested. The only thing that feels wrong is the convention. You have been taught that legs go on the floor and backs go behind you. But the chair itself does not care. Only your training cares.

The same is true of so many perceptual assumptions. You assume that a photograph shows something that happened. But that is a convention, not a fact. You assume that a voice belongs to the person it sounds like. But that is a convention, not a fact. The conventions have served you well for most of your life. But in the digital age, they are being exploited. And you need to learn when to trust them and when to question them.

Lesson Three: Function Survives Inversion

The most remarkable thing about The Throne is that it works perfectly even when inverted. The function – supporting a human body in a seated position – does not depend on orientation.

This is a profound lesson about perception. The function of an image is to convey information. But does that function depend on the image being real? If an AI-generated image tells you something true, is it less valuable than a photograph that tells you the same truth? If a cloned voice delivers an accurate message, is it less trustworthy than an authentic voice?

These are not easy questions. The Throne does not answer them. It raises them. It invites you to think about whether function can survive the inversion of our assumptions about reality and authenticity.

Lesson Four: The Object Does Not Change, But Your Perception Does

The Throne is the same object whether you sit on it normally or upside down. Nothing about the chair changes. The wood is the same. The symmetry is the same. The function is the same.

But your perception of the chair changes completely. When you sit on it normally, it is invisible. You do not notice it. When you sit on it upside down, it becomes strange, noticeable, even humorous. You cannot stop looking at it.

The object did not change. Your perception changed. And your perception changed because your expectations were violated.

This is the core mechanism of Post-Perceptual art. The artwork does not need to change. It only needs to disrupt your expectations. The disruption happens inside you. And once it happens, you cannot go back. You have seen the chair upside down. You will never see chairs the same way again.

Lesson Five: The Most Familiar Things Deserve the Most Questioning

We tend to question the strange and accept the familiar. An unusual object makes us curious. An ordinary object makes us bored. We save our doubt for the exceptions and give our trust to the rule.

The Throne reverses this. It takes the most ordinary object – a chair – and makes it strange. It forces you to question something you have never questioned before. And once you have questioned the chair, you can question other familiar things. The photograph. The video. The voice. The news headline. The social media post.

The Throne teaches that familiarity is not a reason to trust. Sometimes, it is a reason to question more.

Part Four: The Throne in the Context of Art History

The Throne did not appear from nowhere. It stands in a long tradition of artists who have used ordinary objects to raise philosophical questions.

Marcel Duchamp and the Readymade

In 1917, Marcel Duchamp submitted a urinal to an art exhibition. He signed it with a fake name. He called it "Fountain." He asked: "What is art?" The urinal was ordinary. The context was extraordinary. The question changed art forever.

The Throne asks a different question. Duchamp asked: "Can an ordinary object be art?" The Throne asks: "Can an ordinary object teach us about perception?" Duchamp took a urinal out of its functional context and put it in an art context. The Throne stays in its functional context. You can sit on it. It remains a chair. The question is not about art. It is about perception.

René Magritte and The Treachery of Images

In 1929, René Magritte painted a picture of a pipe with the words "this is not a pipe" written beneath it. He asked: "Is the image the same as the thing it represents?" His answer was no. The painting is not the pipe. You cannot smoke it.

The Throne asks a different question. Magritte asked about representation. The Throne asks about function. Magritte said: "This image of a pipe is not a real pipe." The Throne says: "This real chair is still a chair even when you turn it upside down. So what does 'upside down' even mean?"

Joseph Kosuth and Conceptual Art

In 1965, Joseph Kosuth created "One and Three Chairs." He displayed three things: a real chair, a photograph of that chair, and a dictionary definition of the word "chair." He asked: "What is the essence of a chair? Is it the physical object? The image? The definition?"

The Throne asks a similar question but gives a different answer. Kosuth suggested that the essence of a chair might be its concept. The Throne suggests that the essence of a chair might be its function – and that function is more stable than our assumptions about orientation.

The Throne's Unique Contribution

What makes The Throne different from these predecessors? Three things.

First, The Throne is functional. Duchamp's urinal was not usable. Magritte's pipe was not smokable. Kosuth's chair was usable, but the work was about the concept, not the function. The Throne is designed to be used. You are invited to sit on it. The experience is physical, not just intellectual.

Second, The Throne is symmetrical. The other artists relied on the gap between image and reality, or between object and concept. The Throne relies on symmetry – the fact that the object looks the same from both orientations. The confusion is built into the object itself, not imposed by context or language.

Third, The Throne is interactive. You do not just look at it. You sit on it. You flip it. You test it. Your body is involved in the question. This is the essence of Post-Perceptual art: perception is not just mental. It is physical, embodied, and active.

Part Five: The Throne as a Symbol for the Digital Age

Why does the digital age need a chair as its symbol?

Because the digital age has inverted our relationship with reality, just as The Throne inverts our relationship with chairs.

Before the digital age, reality was the ground and images were the figure. Reality came first. Images came second. Images referred to reality. They were evidence of reality. They were less real than reality.

In the digital age, this relationship has inverted. Images are often more vivid, more compelling, more emotionally powerful than reality. We spend more time looking at screens than looking at the world. We experience events through images before we experience them directly. The image comes first. Reality comes second.

This inversion is disorienting. It is like sitting on a chair upside down. Everything looks the same – the chair is still a chair, the image is still an image – but something feels wrong. The orientation has changed. The conventions have shifted. The ground is no longer solid beneath our feet.

The Throne symbolizes this inversion. It looks like a chair. It functions like a chair. But it is upside down. You can sit on it. You can be comfortable. But you know, somewhere in your body, that something is not quite right.

That feeling – that slight, persistent unease – is the feeling of living in the digital age. The Throne gives that feeling a name, a shape, and a place to sit.

Part Six: Experiencing The Throne

The best way to understand The Throne is to sit on it. Since you may not be able to visit an exhibition where it is displayed, let me describe the experience as vividly as I can.

First Encounter

You enter a quiet room. The lighting is soft. The walls are white. In the center of the room stands a single chair. It looks ordinary. Oak wood. Simple design. Nothing special.

You approach. You notice that the chair is perfectly symmetrical. The legs are identical on both sides. The back is straight. The seat is level. You cannot tell, just by looking, which end is supposed to be up.

The Decision

You have a choice. You can sit on the chair the way you have always sat on chairs – legs on the floor, back behind you. Or you can experiment. You can flip the chair over and sit on it upside down.

Most people hesitate. They walk around the chair. They look at it from different angles. They touch the wood. They test the stability. They think about what they are supposed to do.

The Normal Sit

If you sit on it normally, you feel what you have felt thousands of times before. The chair supports you. It is comfortable. It is unremarkable. You could sit here for hours without thinking about the chair at all.

But something is different. You know the chair is symmetrical. You know you could have sat on it upside down. That knowledge stays with you, even as you sit normally. The chair is no longer invisible. You are aware of it. You are aware of your choice.

The Inverted Sit

If you flip the chair over and sit on it upside down, you feel strange. Your legs are in the air. Your back is resting against what used to be the front of the seat. Your feet may dangle or rest on the legs. The position is unfamiliar but not uncomfortable.

You laugh. You feel silly. You look around to see if anyone is watching. Then you settle in. The chair holds you. It works. The strangeness fades. You realize that nothing bad has happened. The world did not end. The chair did not break. You are fine.

The Aftermath

Whether you sat normally or upside down, you leave the room changed. You have seen a chair that works in two orientations. You have experienced the inversion of the most familiar object. You will never look at chairs the same way again.

And more importantly, you will never look at other familiar things the same way again. The photograph. The video. The voice. The news headline. The social media post. If a chair can be inverted, what else can be inverted? What other assumptions are hiding in plain sight, waiting to be questioned?

Part Seven: The Throne as an Invitation

The Throne is not a command. It does not tell you what to think. It does not tell you which orientation is correct. It does not tell you that your perception is wrong.

The Throne is an invitation. It invites you to pause. To look. To question. To experiment. To sit, literally and metaphorically, with uncertainty.

This is the spirit of Post-Perception. The movement does not claim to have all the answers. It does not offer a simple formula for distinguishing real from fake. It does not promise that you will never be deceived again.

What it offers is something more valuable. It offers practice. It offers training. It offers a space where you can experience perceptual confusion safely, without stakes, without consequences. It offers a chair that teaches you to question the ground beneath your feet.

The Throne is the symbol of this offer. It is simple. It is ordinary. It is functional. And it is waiting for you to sit on it – one way or the other, right side up or upside down, according to your convention or against it.

The chair does not care. The chair only asks.

What is a chair? Is what we see enough to know what something is? If the most familiar object can be inverted, what else in your perception is ready to be turned upside down?

Sit with those questions. Let them be uncomfortable. Let them change you.

That is what The Throne is for.



About the Author

Ibrahim Shalaby (b. 1966, Kafr El-Sheikh, Egypt) is a visual artist, researcher, and the founder of the Post-Perception movement. Over three decades, he has developed a body of work spanning painting, collage, photography, performance, installation, and video art. He has held eighteen solo exhibitions and participated in over eighty group exhibitions across Egypt, Spain, Venezuela, Qatar, Iraq, and

Malta. In 2026, his installation "Isolation" was selected for the Egypt Pavilion at the Malta Biennale. He is the author of the six-volume "Alban Alwan" series. A PhD dissertation has been written about his work at Ain Shams University, and he has been documented by the Serbian Ministry of Culture in the publication "Ambassador of Art."

ORCID iD: 0009-0008-4867-1416

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